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THE COUNTRY'S QUICK-commerce market, once defined by a simple race to open dark stores closer to consumers, is entering a new phase. The race is no longer just about who can deliver in 10 minutes, open the most number of stores or capture the largest share of orders. The era of growth at all costs is beginning to give way to a more unforgiving question—who can turn scale into a business that makes money, and how many such businesses can India sustain?

As of Q1FY27, Blinkit is the only major player to become EBITDA positive. EBITDA stands for earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortisation. Its adjusted EBITDA margin stood at 0.6%, while EBITDA per order was approximately ₹3. Instamart, despite improving its economics, was losing around ₹68 per order, while Zepto's EBITDA loss was nearly ₹60 per order as of Q4FY26. According to Swiggy's inputs for Instamart, there has been improvement of +₹29 per order for adjusted EBITDA/order, so the loss per order has reduced considerably in last one year and its contribution (per order) has also improved the most in the industry.

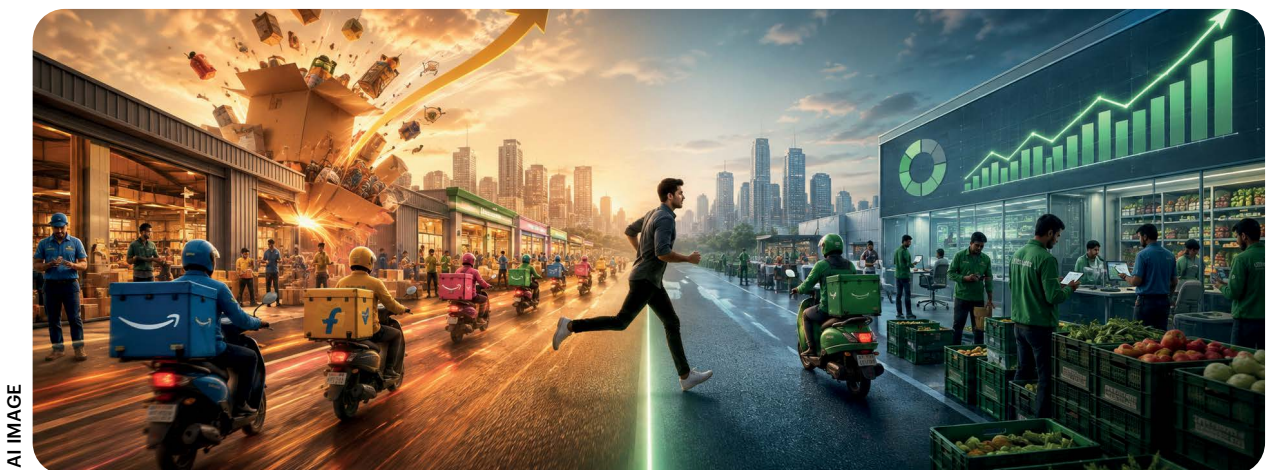
The gap is a reminder that the quick-commerce race cannot be judged simply by order volumes, gross merchandise value (GMV) or dark-store counts. The real test is what remains after the cost of fulfilling those orders.

There is also another story playing out in the sector and there are clear signs of a reset.

CHANGING DYNAMICS

Global e-commerce major Amazon is stepping up its India bet, with plans to invest \$48 billion through

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► **Amazon is stepping up its India bet, with plans to invest \$48 billion through 2030, while Indian e-commerce giant Flipkart is pouring resources into its quick commerce offering, Minutes**

► **Zepto has put its listing plans on hold amid questions around valuation and profitability. Swiggy has shuffled the leadership at Instamart, and BigBasket has brought in a new CEO**

► **UBS's recent research shows that discounts have stabilised at around 19-20% over the past three-four months, compared with a more aggressive period between October 2025 and March 2026**

► **The metrics that investors look for have changed. In a business where revenue and order growth can mask cash burn, money lost per order is increasingly becoming the more telling metric**